The Ten Words

Exodus 19–20

The big idea: God rescued Israel first, then brought them to Sinai and gave them his law. He carried them on eagles' wings, came down on the mountain in fire, and spoke the Ten Words, beginning with grace.

Before you meet: Read

Exodus 19:1–20 | Exodus 20:1–21

Open (5 minutes)

When you hear the word law, what comes to mind first? Did you grow up with rules that felt loving, or rules that felt harsh?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on _____ wings and brought you to _____." *(Exodus 19:4)*

"You shall be my treasured _____ among all peoples, for all the earth is mine; and you shall be to me a kingdom of _____ and a holy nation." *(Exodus 19:5–6)*

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of _____." *(Exodus 20:2)*

Discuss

1. God rescued Israel before he gave them the law. Why does that order matter? What would change if it were the other way around? *Exodus 19:4; 20:2*

2. God called Israel "a kingdom of priests." Peter calls the church "a royal priesthood." What could that look like for you this week? *Exodus 19:6; 1 Peter 2:9*

3. Why were the people afraid at Sinai? Is that kind of fear of God healthy or harmful? Why? *Exodus 19:16–18; 20:18–21*

4. Read the Ten Commandments in Exodus 20:1–17. Which one do you find hardest to keep, and why? *Exodus 20:1–17*

Memory verse

> *"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."*
>
> **Exodus 20:2**

Pray

Thank God that he rescued you before he asked anything of you. Ask him for a heart that loves his commands because they come from your Father.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 17

The Ten Words

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Exodus 19:3–6 and 20:1–21 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Exodus 24 and 32–34).

Main points to land

1. Rescue comes before law. The Ten Commandments open with what God has already done (Exodus 20:2). We obey because we have been rescued, not in order to be rescued (WSC 44).
2. God is holy. At Sinai sinful people could not come near him, and they needed a mediator to stand between them and God (20:19, 21; Deuteronomy 5:5).
3. Jesus summed up the whole law in two commands: love God with all your heart, and love your neighbor as yourself (Matt. 22:37–40; WSC 42).

Answer key (Observe)

1. eagles'; myself
2. possession; priests
3. slavery

Questions people will ask

Should Christians worship on Saturday, since the commandment names the seventh day?
One day in seven belongs to God, a pattern older than Israel (Genesis 2:3). Since Jesus rose on the first day of the week, his people have gathered on that day, "the Lord's day" (Revelation 1:10). The Westminster Confession calls it the Christian Sabbath (WCF 21.7).

Closing prayer

Lord, you are the God who brought us out. You carried us on eagles' wings and brought us to yourself. Thank you for your good law, and thank you for Jesus, the Mediator who brings us near. Write your law on our hearts. Amen.